> Several of my native friends in the city come daily to see me, and all agree without one dissenting voice that we have brought the whole of our misfortunes upon ourselves, through the apathy & imbecility displayed at the commencement of the outbreak.
>
> They also tell me that our safety in the retreat depends solely upon ourselves, that no dependence is to be placed in the promises of any of the Chiefs, every one of whom knows that they are in a measure paid beforehand to do their utmost to destroy us.[10]

Mohan Lal, who had unrivalled contacts throughout Kabul, sent a whole succession of warnings that the British were heading straight into an ambush, and passed on explicit intelligence from the Qizilbash chiefs that the British would all be massacred; but he was ignored.[11] Macabre rumours began to circulate that the Afghans would seize all the British women and kill all the British men with the single exception of one who would be taken to the entrance of the Khyber Pass, where he would be left, legless and armless, with a note pinned to his chest to warn the British never again to attempt to enter Afghanistan. Lady Sale, always willing to stare the truth in the face, wrote bleakly in her diary the night before the retreat that 'the Affghans tell us we are doomed'.[12]

No one did more to warn the British of the fate that awaited them in the passes than Shah Shuja himself. Mohammad Husain Herati recorded that 'His Majesty wrote to Pottinger: "To leave the cantonment in the depths of this harsh winter is an act of extreme folly, beware, do not think of going to Jalalabad! If you must leave the cantonment, then come and spend the winter with us in the Bala Hisar fort, where we will await the end of winter together, and if supplies run out, we will make sorties to plunder round about for our survival." But this offer was not accepted?. . .'[13]

As Mohan Lal pointed out, the decision of the British to abandon Shuja was of course a major breach of faith. 'No regard was shown to the articles of the Tripartite Treaty,' he wrote, 'and Shah Shuja ul-Mulk was left at the mercy of his enemies, to whom we had given shelter during his government of the last two years. Had it not been for us, he, acting as an independent sovereign, would have destroyed the Barakzais, and thus have freed us and himself from these fatal consequences.'[14]

Shuja himself seemed less upset and resentful of the British betrayal than simply baffled by the amazing stupidity of his allies. Over his years in Ludhiana, despite his frequent differences with his British hosts, he had come to admire the smooth efficiency of the Company's administration, but what he had seen over the previous six weeks defied belief: how could the